

Provision Is the Penny; Reward Is the Life Given Away

When the first came, they supposed they should have received more, but they also received every man a penny.

When they received it, they murmured against the good man of the house, saying, "These last have worked only one hour. What kind of deal is this? They worked one hour and received the same as us, and we worked eleven, bore the burden and heat of the day, and got the same."

He answered one of them:

Friend, I do thee no wrong: didst not thou agree with me for a penny?

Take that thine is, and go thy way: I will give unto this last, even as unto thee.

Is it not lawful for me to do what I will with mine own? Is thine eye evil, because I am good?

Then Jesus concludes:

So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

When you link that thought together, He is telling you the process that causes you to be chosen. The first will be last, and the last will be first. The man who makes himself first comes in last in the kingdom. The man who makes himself the slave and servant comes in first in God's kingdom.

Many are called, but few are chosen.

When I thought about this reward, the hours these men worked, what they were paid, and the rich young ruler, I could see the connection. The rich young ruler asked, "What thing do I lack?" Jesus said, "If you want to be perfect, trade the wealth of this life. Trade your treasure. Sell all of it, give it to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven."

Peter could not hold back. He said, "We have done that. We have forsaken all to follow You. What are we going to get?"

Peter was saying, "We are like this rich young ruler would have been. We forsook all to follow You. You said he would have treasure in heaven if he gave all his wealth away and followed You. What do we get?"

Jesus answered, "Peter, in the regeneration, you who have forsaken all to follow Me will rule and reign with Me. You will judge the twelve tribes of Israel from twelve thrones. That is the treasure in heaven you are going to have because you have forsaken all."

Then He says no man has forsaken houses, lands, brothers, sisters, father, mother, wife, or children for His sake who will not receive a hundredfold.

He is not talking about getting up one day and saying, "Wife and children of mine, I am forsaking you. You support yourself. I am going to the mission field."

He is saying that no matter what anyone or anything says, you sell out to the Lord Jesus Christ. If anyone wants to go with you, let them come. But if they will not go, and the Word of God does not authorize you to go back for them or wait for them, you must go on.

In this life your reward will be houses, lands, brothers, mothers, and sisters a hundredfold. You will inherit lands and people saved. That becomes treasure in the life to come. Because you gave your life here, you qualify to rule and reign with Him there.

Then Jesus says, "Let Me tell you how the kingdom works."

The men who worked eleven hours and were paid for one thought they should be paid for eleven more. What they were saying was, "Giving my life is not enough. I want the other eleven now. I am like the rich young ruler. I am not going to sell my life out for over there and get only the one penny, the one day's wage. I want what is coming to me now."

Many are called, but few are chosen.

The parable outlines the basis by which you are chosen. If you work twelve hours and get paid for one, then the rest of your labor goes to the kingdom. The process of being chosen asks this: do you want your labor and your paycheck now, to exalt yourself, or do you want to forsake all, work your whole life, and reap the benefit in the next lifetime?

The qualifying process is whether you want it now or there.

The mother of the sons of Zebedee said, "My sons really want to rule with You."

Jesus said, "Before that, can they drink of My cup? I came not to be ministered to, but to minister and give My life a ransom for many."

They wanted left-hand and right-hand authority on His thrones. Jesus said the Gentiles just take authority, but it is not so among you.

The one who makes himself a slave in this life belongs to Him. Everything about his life, everything he does, everything he has, every commandment he obeys, lays treasure up in the kingdom. That is all it does.

The qualifying process is this: how much do you want to be paid for now, and how much do you want to be paid for then?

I used to think I wanted the good life now, and then I wanted reward too. I wanted all of it now.

Let me ask you something. As much as our gospel has revolved around prosperity, you might as well know this is not the first time. History is dotted with it, and so is the Word.

If we are steeped in the good life--mansions, cameras, estates, six or seven cars, Lexuses--and one day you have them, and the next you are in prison for your faith, how will that affect your walk? Or if the devil comes in and beats it all away from you, takes every bit of it away, how is your relationship with God?

Are you going to serve Him faithfully if you do not get paid for the other three, six, or eleven hours?

Many are called, few are chosen. Are you able?

The householder paid them all the same, whether they worked twelve hours or one. I want to know what He promised me in payment. I know one hour's labor, in their breakdown, is thirty-two dollars. That is not bad for a day's labor. The man who worked twelve hours got thirty-two. The man who worked one hour got thirty-two.

I want to know what He promised me for laboring in the kingdom personally.

Most of us take ninety percent, and once in a while, if it does not disturb our television payments, we squeeze out a little more. As a national average, we are already spending ten cents on the dollar more than we make. Credit cards are full. It is a trap of the devil. If we had been gospel-minded, we would not have fallen into the trap.

Once you start living the good life and believe God owes you the good life, you think He can give you the good life and the kingdom too.

The process that causes me to be chosen is how much of my life I am willing to give.

The way Gary was teaching on this thrilled me. When we become stewards, we often give God ten percent and keep ninety. Then when we start prospering, we give Him ten percent back and keep the increase. It is almost impossible to prosper the kingdom of God without prospering yourself ninety percent.

Gary has some interesting testimonies. By this coming Monday, he will have given more than he gave all last year, twice the amount he gave last year, and it has not hurt the living he is doing now at all.

He did something that made God know the increase was His and the living was Gary's. Since God knew the increase was His, He started pouring out increase. Gary has doubled the amount he has given because God brought in what he gave.

When Gary wants an increase, he goes to God and says, "I need this and that," and they work it out. But God knows everything above that is His.

I never heard anything like that in my life.

Gary worked out the parable of the pounds, and it is true. How is a man going to get greedy when everything that comes in over a certain amount belongs to God?

If he got a million-dollar check, he would say, "I still have my living, and this is His." Before, he did not have the anointing on his finances. Now there is an anointing in the finances.

If you can get an anointing in your finances, and spend a couple of years faithfully handling the pound that belongs to the Lord, you can go before Him and say, "In light of the million coming, I would like to double the things I am doing now. God, I am going to increase my part to this much." He will go with you because He knows everything above that is still His.

When Jesus said many are called and few are chosen, the process that causes you to be chosen is the process in that parable.

If you worked all your life and He paid you that day's wage, and someone else worked one hour and got the same promise He gives to a laborer on this earth, would you still be willing for all the other labor you did to be His? That is the process by which you are chosen.

I want to know what the penny, the day's wage, is. A laborer on this earth needs food, water, clothes, cars, and provision. What is that wage? What did He promise me I could have? Depending on how much I want to be chosen, the rest is His.

He says that with this inheritance I will have persecution. I do not mind persecution for righteousness' sake because I know He is with me.

But I will not take persecution directly from the devil, from poverty. I will not take persecution from sickness and disease. I will not take those things from him because that is one-on-one. I have power over his power.

I do not have power over people. God wants people saved, so He asks me to go get them saved. No matter what they do to me, He wants me to know their salvation is more important to Him than what they can temporarily do to me on this earth.

He loved me enough for somebody to get me saved. He wants me to love others enough to get them saved. He expects me to bear up under any persecution He sends me into.

But I will not take persecution from the devil directly. I do not like his disease, torment, threats, or poverty. I do not intend to put up with any of it.

You may have a devil, but you have authority on this earth. That devil may get you to torment me. I have power over devils, but if you give him rule in your life, you might hurt me. You may treat me mean and persecute me. That is okay because that is part of being chosen.

I am His slave, and I will never ask anything except eternity. Promise me eternity, and I will go in there. I do not care. I do not belong to myself anymore.

I will come out the other end of the Amazon, and my whole life will have been given to making mothers, brothers, sisters, and fathers in my family. If you hand me a dollar and a half to represent the comforts of this life and all the good things I could have had, I do not care. A dollar and a half is enough.

That parable is a choosing process.

One missionary said, "I have never seen the righteous forsaken, nor his seed begging bread. I do not know what that means, because my friends have starved and died, and I have starved and nobody brought me in."

There has to be an answer somewhere.

I do not believe in persecution from the devil directly. Jesus did the miracles of the loaves and fishes not to show off, but because if there is no other way for provision, then gather them around, because we are about to have a miracle.

I will not take that kind of persecution. That is His grace toward me, not reward. That is part of the promise.

I want to know what He promised me for my lifetime of labor on earth. I know what I get over there. What do I get now? Do I get the Lexuses and the mansions? What do I get?

It is hard for me to reconcile myself to abundance when another person lies at my feet and perishes for necessity anywhere in the world. How do you justify that?

I understand Mother Teresa's reasoning: as long as one person does not have a toothbrush, I will not have two. I understand the vow of poverty, though the vow of poverty is not scriptural. His supply is. But I understand it very well.

There will be a day when we hold billions between people and their need, and they will listen because we will meet their needs on every level. By the time we are done with them, they will want God more than they want the food.

Money was made to serve the kingdom in the hands of servants, not to make you a servant to it.

As long as you have yourself first, quit crying prosperity. You may get all the money and serve yourself first, but your reward is here.

Heaven is reward enough. You cannot tell me, after you survive the outer darkness ordeal, after you gnash your teeth in the presence of His glory over all you forfeited, after you see the apostles, rewards, and thrones, that it will not matter. The wailing and gnashing of teeth in the presence of His glory is when your heart is opened, secrets are revealed, and you see who you really served. Then He heals you, wipes your tears away, and gives you your place in eternity.

But there are places.

The way Jesus will treat you for selling out here is unfathomable.

Gary is the first man I have heard who really had the anointing of God on his finances without having to hurt people to get it. I am talking about preachers too.

The man who worked twelve hours and the man who worked one both received the promise for this lifetime. But the question is whether that promise is enough for you. Do you want the other eleven too? That is the process by which you are chosen.

You can make money. You can put your life into anything. You might be very good at making money. What are you going to do with your life?

I want to know what I get. What did He promise me in this life?

That is why I will not put up with persecution from the devil one-on-one. I have the promise of the laborer. He promised me a penny for the day. He promised me provision for my life. The devil cannot have my late bills. He cannot cause them. He cannot throw me into lack. The promise I have from Him is provision.

Everything over provision is His. I want provision for the rest of the world, and that is His promise.

Matthew 6 says:

For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.

But if thine eye be evil, thy whole body shall be full of darkness.

No man can serve two masters: for either he will hate the one, and love the other; or else he will hold to the one, and despise the other. Ye cannot serve God and mammon.

Therefore I say unto you, Take no thought for your life, what ye shall eat, or what ye shall drink; nor yet for your body, what ye shall put on. Is not the life more than meat, and the body than raiment?

Look at the fowls of the air. They do not sow or reap. They do not gather into barns or have bank accounts, yet your heavenly Father feeds them. Are you not worth more than they are?

Which of you, by taking thought, can add one cubit to his stature?

Why take thought for clothing? Consider the lilies of the field. They do not toil or spin, yet Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of them. If God clothes the grass of the field, which today is and tomorrow is cast into the oven, how much more will He clothe you, O you of little faith?

Therefore, you do not have to take thought for your life, saying, "What shall we eat? What shall we drink? What shall we wear?" After all these things the Gentiles seek. Your heavenly Father knows you need them.

But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

Take therefore no thought for the morrow: for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself. Sufficient unto the day is the evil thereof.

I have my promise. No matter where I go or what I do, I will eat. I will be clothed. He has promised me provision.

That is the penny: one hour or twelve. That is what I get. How much I give to Him is up to me.

If I work one hour, I get provision. If I work twelve and get paid for one, I get provision and I get chosen.

Gary, give the preview.

Pinch Matthew 6 and Matthew 20 together between your fingers.

In the parable Dave taught tonight, notice Matthew 20:15:

Is it not lawful for me to do what I will with mine own? Is thine eye evil, because I am good?

Mark that phrase: "Is thine eye evil?"

Now go to Matthew 6:19:

Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves break through and steal:

But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break through nor steal:

For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.

But if thine eye be evil...

What did He say in Matthew 20? "Is thine eye evil?" He is talking about the same thing. We will get into that in detail later.

We are in uncharted ground now. We do not have many patterns to follow that I know of. I do not know where this is being taught. All I know to do is teach, make sure I am living what I am teaching, and then report back to you.

I keep crunching the numbers as things happen and report.

Technically, Sue and I could write our next pound tonight. There is enough in my checkbook, and that one will make us double last year. But technically I cannot, because it takes time for deposits from out-of-state checks to clear the bank. Probably by Sunday we will be able to do that one. When we do, in the fifth month, we will have given at least twice what we gave all last year.

Last year we gave twenty percent, and we have not diminished ourselves at all. In fact, to this date, we have gone out about three hundred dollars more than we did last year. That is what I mean: there is an anointing now that was not there.

The big question everybody asks me is about debt. "Should I get out of debt first?"

This is not law. All I can do is report.

For years I thought like that. "If I could ever get completely out of debt, then I could really serve the Lord. Then I could really put a bunch in."

As long as I thought that way, the result was this: if increase came, it was going on my debt first. As long as I thought that way, no anointing ever showed up. Nothing supernatural really happened with my finances.

Then we made the decision: we had been making these payments, and we included the payments in our budget. We set a certain amount and said, "Anything above this is Yours."

All of a sudden, increase came. We have already put more in this year than our total debt.

The devil says, "You are stupid."

No, I am not. I am not diminished from what I was doing last year. But I am rapidly becoming a steward God can trust to handle finances.

There is an anointing coming now that was never there while my mindset was, "If increase comes, it goes on my debt first."

When I said, "God, You did not make these debts. I did. You are going to help me get out of this one way or another, even if I just pay them all off. But I want to be Your steward now. I do not want to wait ten years to start. I want Dave on television now. I want him in Japan next year. Let us get with the program."

As soon as we made that decision, increase came. He has already brought more through us than my debt. But I cannot use that on the debt. If I did, do you think that anointing would stay? What would I prove? That I am unfaithful and cannot be trusted to keep my word.

Here is another way to look at it. We tend to think, "If I could get out of debt, then I could really serve the Lord financially."

I thought like that too. But once I realized the anointing had shown up and had brought in more than my debt, the Lord had me put a pencil to it. If I had used the increase and paid off my personal debts, the only difference it would have made in my budget would have been three

hundred dollars a month.

If I were debt-free right now, there would be three hundred dollars I would not have to use on debt. Without an anointing, that is all I could put into the gospel. It would take over three years to put in what we have already put in during five months.

Our minds are fallen. We do not think things through. We hate payments, but we do not pencil it out. If you were debt-free, how much would really be freed up each month without the anointing?

God is telling us, "You can become My steward right now. You do not have to be diminished. We can talk about raises every few months. But the increase is Mine."

This is all the Lord. I am only giving the report. It is like when Peter or another disciple came back from an evangelistic trip and reported how many were saved and baptized in the Holy Ghost. Sue and I are doing these things, and this is what happened with our money. We are just telling what happens as you make these adjustments.

Lester Sumrall said one time, "If I die with a million dollars in the bank, I died a traitor to the gospel."

Isn't that interesting?

Did you learn anything tonight?